

Which Institutions Lose Public Trust During Counterinsurgency? Evidence from Cameroon's Anglophone Crisis

BRICE ROMUALD GUEYAP KOUNGA*

Department of Economics, Western University, London, Ontario, Canada

bgueyapk@uwo.ca

Abstract

Which institutions lose public trust during counterinsurgency, and which retain it? I compare trust in eleven institutions across Afrobarometer surveys of Cameroon in 2015, 2018, 2021, and 2022, comparing changes in the Northwest and Southwest, the crisis's core, with the adjacent West and Littoral regions. Police trust shows the largest divergence: it fell from 31% to 10% in the conflict regions while rising outside them, a difference in changes of 29 percentage points by 2022, with the ruling party and army close behind. Small coefficients conceal distinct trajectories: parliament declined in both groups, and traditional leaders recovered moderate but not strong trust. The police deficit is the largest in the battery and stable across every comparison group, weighting scheme, and coding; the pattern across institutions is most consistent with their roles in the conflict. Four-region inference, multiple testing, and changing survey access qualify comparisons between coefficients, not the central finding.

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1 Introduction

Which institutions lose public trust during counterinsurgency? The question matters because governments fight insurgencies through institutions that also police communities, administer justice, organise elections, and represent citizens. A deterioration in confidence in one institution need not extend to all the others. Nor does confidence retained by a community leader necessarily compensate for distrust of the police. Understanding these differences is important both for explaining political legitimacy during conflict and for identifying the relationships that any subsequent settlement must repair.

Research on war and social behaviour provides reasons to expect substantial change without establishing a uniform direction. Bauer et al. (2016) show that violence can co-exist with greater local cooperation, often within bounded communities. Barceló's (2026) meta-analysis likewise finds varied attitudinal and behavioural legacies rather than a general increase or decrease in trust. Much of this evidence concerns cooperation, identity, and interpersonal relations. The related question of confidence in distinct public institutions requires direct comparison: citizens may distrust an institution associated with coercion while continuing to trust another that provides assistance or mediates disputes.

I examine that comparative question during Cameroon's Anglophone crisis. Its geographic concentration and the repeated use of a common survey battery permit comparison of eleven institutions before and after the onset of armed conflict. The analysis uses Afrobarometer surveys from 2015, 2018, 2021, and 2022, comparing the Northwest and Southwest with the adjacent West and Littoral regions. A 2013 survey supplies an additional pre-crisis observation for nine of the institutions. These are repeated cross-sections of respondents interviewed in each region, not a panel of individuals followed through the conflict.

The central argument is that institutions' roles provide a useful starting point for explaining differentiated trust. Direct participation in coercion, responsibility for political decisions, and the capacity to represent or protect communities imply different expectations.

Geographic proximity and formal status alone do not specify these relationships. Traditional leaders enter the comparison because they combine local social authority with varying connections to the state. Their ambiguous position is analytically useful alongside the other ten institutions; the paper does not make their experience a separate research question or treat them as the benchmark against which all institutions should be assessed.

The argument also concerns the public doing the evaluating. A security operation may be experienced as a threat in one region and understood as protection in another. People outside the conflict's core may support the government's response, criticise it, or revise their opinions for reasons unrelated to the war. The West and Littoral regions therefore provide a comparative trajectory, not an automatically unaffected counterfactual. I present the underlying trust levels before interpreting differences in changes.

Three descriptive findings organise the analysis. First, police trust declined by 21.1 percentage points in the conflict regions between 2015 and 2022 while increasing by 7.5 points in the comparison regions. The resulting -28.6 -point difference is the largest negative estimate among the eleven institutions at the final survey. The ruling party and army also register substantial negative differences. Second, similar-looking relative estimates can conceal quite different experiences. Parliament's near-zero difference reflects falling trust in both groups, whereas much of the opposition's negative difference reflects a rise in comparison-region trust. Third, the apparent recovery of traditional leaders depends on the intensity of trust being measured: moderate-or-high trust rebounds, but the share expressing the highest category does not.

The clearest finding is the police deficit: the largest estimate in the battery, and stable across every comparison group, weighting scheme, and coding of the outcome examined below. What the design cannot deliver with equal force is a statistically firm separation of all eleven coefficient magnitudes. The main design contains only four administrative regions. Conventional clustered tests, wild-bootstrap calculations, and regional placebo comparisons give different assessments of uncertainty. Assessments of which institutions stand out de-

pend on how the placebo statistics are standardised. Changes in survey access and sample composition present an additional concern that statistical corrections cannot remove.

The paper contributes an institution-specific account of trust trajectories during a single counterinsurgency and an explicit separation of within-region change from between-region divergence. It complements Afrobarometer research on insecurity in Mali, where Diallo (2025) finds relationships that vary with regime and level of insecurity. Here, the emphasis is on differences across institutions and across regional publics over successive surveys. The remainder develops the expectations, explains the setting and data, presents descriptive trends and difference-in-differences estimates, and assesses their interpretation and limits.

2 Institutions and regional publics during counterinsurgency

Trust in a named institution is an evaluation of that institution, although evaluations can draw on shared views of government, political identity, and economic conditions. The question is not simply whether violence makes people less trusting. It is which actors they associate with protection, harm, representation, and accountability, and whether those associations extend across institutions. Levi and Sacks (2009) link legitimating beliefs to assessments of government performance and fairness. This suggests attention to what institutions do and how their conduct is interpreted, without equating a survey response about trust with a complete measure of state legitimacy.

Three broad expectations help structure the comparison. A proximity account anticipates particularly large changes for institutions encountered locally. A formal-status account anticipates a common response toward state institutions relative to community authorities. A role-based account instead anticipates differences according to institutions' involvement in coercion, political responsibility, and mediation. These accounts overlap. Police can be simultaneously local, formal, and coercive; chiefs can be local and legally integrated into the state. The comparison therefore evaluates the plausibility and limits of broad explanations

rather than cleanly isolating mutually exclusive mechanisms.

For the police and army, counterinsurgency can make the tension between protection and coercion especially visible. Security provision may sustain confidence when citizens regard force as necessary and discriminate. Abuses, arbitrary intervention or failure to protect can instead erode it. The expectation is conditional on citizens' assessments, rather than a universal negative effect of security presence. In Afghanistan, Lyall, Blair, and Imai (2013) find asymmetric responses to harm by different combatants, indicating that identity and attribution mediate reactions to violence. Their evidence cautions against assuming that equivalent conduct by any actor produces an equivalent political response. Terrorist violence points the same way: across eight jihadist attacks that struck during European Social Survey fieldwork, Nägel, Nivette, and Czymara (2024) find no general rally in institutional trust but institution-specific responses, with parliament and politicians tilting weakly positive while the police and the legal system are unchanged or slightly negative. Even outside civil war, trust responses to political violence are institution-specific, which is why the comparison here measures institutions separately.

Courts of law may also become associated with the state's coercive response, particularly when prosecution and detention are politically salient. Yet the trust item does not distinguish ordinary courts from military tribunals or identify the respondent's reason for an evaluation. A negative change in court trust would be consistent with an accountability account, but would not establish which judicial practices caused it. More generally, improving some aspects of security does not guarantee greater trust. Blair, Karim, and Morse's (2019) Liberian police experiment improved several outcomes but did not increase trust in the police, courts or government. Institutional confidence must be measured rather than inferred from the presence of services.

Political responsibility extends beyond institutions that directly exercise force. The president and ruling party can both be held accountable for the government's prosecution of a conflict. A role-based explanation should therefore allow losses in trust in both; it cannot

explain away a small presidential regional difference merely by describing the presidency as distant. A national leader may lose trust across the country, producing a small regional contrast despite a substantial decline inside the conflict zone. The ruling party may face a more geographically uneven response. Those possibilities can be distinguished descriptively only by inspecting both groups' trajectories.

The electoral commission, parliament, and local government councils occupy different positions within formal politics. Elections can provide a channel for representation, but can also be associated with exclusion or the perpetuation of incumbent power. Representative institutions might retain confidence where people see them as avenues for assistance or negotiation. They might lose it where they seem unable to constrain violence or address grievances. These expectations do not presume that parliament or councils are independent of the governing regime, or that proximity protects locally elected institutions. Their inclusion tests whether formal institutions share a common pattern despite different functions.

Opposition parties warrant separate attention because dissatisfaction with incumbents need not transfer into confidence in their electoral challengers. Citizens may blame opposition leaders for ineffective representation, reject established electoral politics, or support actors not covered by the trust battery. Outside the core conflict regions, opposition parties may gain credibility for reasons that produce little corresponding change inside them. The survey measures trust in opposition parties collectively, not support for a particular party or for armed separatist organisations. Substitution from government to insurgents cannot be inferred from this item.

Traditional and religious leaders broaden the comparison beyond national political and security institutions. Their local relationships can provide resources for mediation and assistance, but can also expose them to coercion by armed actors and criticism from residents. Traditional authorities are especially difficult to place on a single formal–informal axis. Henn (2023) shows that institutional arrangements condition whether traditional authorities and the state operate as complements or substitutes. In a conflict, state connections might bring pro-

tection and resources, invite accusations of collaboration, or constrain a leader's room for manoeuvre. Religious leaders may retain credibility through community service or mediation, while still being vulnerable to intimidation and perceived political alignment. Neither group is assumed to be uniformly neutral.

These considerations generate a conditional comparative expectation: institutions closely associated with coercion and political responsibility may experience greater losses of trust among populations exposed to the conflict's core than institutions regarded as credible intermediaries. Retention or recovery of confidence in intermediaries is also possible, but depends on their conduct and perceived independence. Evidence would be particularly informative if it showed contrasting changes among equally local institutions and differences within the state's formal apparatus. Even then, measuring trust alone would not reveal the perceptions responsible for those contrasts.

Regional publics are the second part of the argument. Distance from direct violence can change the information available, the salience of security threats, and the attribution of responsibility. Some people outside the core conflict regions may rally behind the state; others may sympathise with grievances or oppose abuses. Displacement, economic disruption, national political events, and contact with affected relatives can transmit consequences beyond the theatre of fighting. International Crisis Group (2019) describes differing Francophone responses and growing calls for dialogue, making a single assumed response outside the Anglophone regions inappropriate.

This has a direct implication for interpretation. A negative difference-in-differences estimate can reflect a decline in the conflict regions, an increase in the comparison regions, or both. A coefficient near zero can coexist with large declines in both groups. The role-based argument is most credible when it explains the underlying regional trajectories, rather than treating every negative relative coefficient as evidence of local trust destruction. It also needs to accommodate evidence that does not fit a simple coercive-versus-intermediary divide.

3 The Cameroonian setting

The Northwest and Southwest largely correspond to the former British Southern Cameroons, which joined the formerly French-administered Republic of Cameroon in 1961. The subsequent erosion of federal arrangements and disputes over the standing of English-language education and common law contributed to a distinct Anglophone grievance. Konings and Nyamnjoh (1997) trace how these grievances became demands for federalism and, for some actors, secession. This history explains why the two regions form a politically meaningful comparison group; the analysis does not estimate the effect of British rather than French colonial rule.

Colonial administration also shaped traditional authority, but not through a uniform contrast between strong British-side chiefs and weak French-side chiefs. Geschiere (1993) documents variation in the ways colonial authorities constructed and governed through chieftaincy. The existence of substantial customary authority on both sides of the former partition means that traditional leadership is a meaningful outcome in both regional groups. Historical differences nevertheless caution against assuming that their trajectories would have been identical in the absence of the crisis.

Lawyers' and teachers' protests began in October 2016 over the treatment of Anglophone legal and educational institutions. The mobilisation broadened, and the government responded with repression and an internet shutdown (Pommerolle and Heungoup 2017). The crisis escalated into armed conflict in late 2017. International Crisis Group (2019) documents widespread displacement, destruction, and insecurity, with the Northwest and Southwest at the centre and spillovers into West and Littoral. The post-2015 surveys therefore occur after the onset of the crisis; they should not be described as observations after the conflict had ended.

The conflict involved several kinds of public authority. Human Rights Watch (2020a) documents abuses by government forces, separatist attacks and abductions, and repression extending beyond the Anglophone regions. The political sphere was also implicated: vi-

olence and threats surrounded the 2020 parliamentary and municipal elections, including attacks on electoral infrastructure (Human Rights Watch 2020b). Traditional and religious leaders faced pressure from armed actors, while some religious leaders sought to convene dialogue (International Crisis Group 2019). These circumstances motivate institutional differentiation, but they do not provide an independent measure of how each respondent attributed responsibility.

West and Littoral offer nearby comparisons, sharing borders, commercial ties, and some social connections with the core conflict regions. Those connections make them useful and imperfect at the same time. They may share economic shocks, receive displaced people, and experience security spillovers. I therefore describe them as comparison regions outside the conflict's core, not as war-free or politically unaffected regions. An alternative comparison uses the seven other regions excluding the Far North, where a separate insurgency creates an additional source of conflict exposure.

4 Data and descriptive trajectories

4.1 Surveys and measurement

I use the Cameroon observations from Afrobarometer Rounds 6–9, fielded in 2015, 2018, 2021, and 2022. The main four-region sample contains 1,920 interviews: 488 in 2015, 480 in 2018, 464 in 2021, and 488 in 2022. Item-specific analysis samples range from 1,799 to 1,880 because some respondents do not give a substantive trust response. Round 5, fielded in 2013, adds a pre-crisis comparison for the nine political and state institutions; its battery does not include traditional or religious leaders. Appendix A documents regional counts, field dates, variable mappings, and coding.

The eleven outcomes are trust in the president, parliament, the electoral commission (Elections Cameroon, or ELECAM), the local government council, the ruling party, opposition parties, the police, the army, courts of law, traditional leaders, and religious leaders.

Each item offers four ordered substantive responses, ranging from no trust to a lot of trust. The main outcome equals one for the upper two categories, somewhat and a lot, and zero for the lower two. Other responses, including not knowing enough to answer, are missing. I use a common threshold to give differences a percentage-point interpretation across institutions, not because the threshold captures every relevant change in confidence.

The harmonisation checks the original SPSS labels and substantive response codes in each round. The same institution and response scale can be followed over time, although comparable wording does not guarantee identical interpretation across languages and interview conditions. The main descriptive means and regressions are unweighted to make their arithmetic directly comparable. Survey-weighted estimates are reported as a sensitivity check. The appendix also reports all four substantive response categories and alternative thresholds, so that changes within the binary categories remain visible.

4.2 Levels before differences in changes

Figures 1 and 2 present the proportion trusting each institution somewhat or a lot in both groups at each main survey. Solid lines with circles identify the conflict regions; dashed lines with squares identify the comparison regions. All panels use the same vertical scale, and the spacing reflects calendar time. These are descriptive sample means, without confidence bands implying that individual interviews are independent geographic treatment units. The appendix provides their exact denominators and conventional regional comparisons, subject to the small-cluster limitations discussed below.

Baseline differences are substantial for some institutions. In 2015, 75.4% of comparison-region respondents trusted the army somewhat or a lot, against 44.4% in the conflict regions. The equivalent presidential shares were 68.8% and 45.5%. Trust in traditional leaders was much closer, at 49.1% and 51.5%. Difference-in-differences does not require identical initial levels, but these gaps demonstrate why the two groups cannot simply be treated as interchangeable populations. A common binary scale also leaves different amounts of room for

increases and decreases depending on the starting distribution.

Table 1 separates the 2015 and 2022 levels from each group’s change. Police trust fell from 30.7% to 9.5% in the conflict regions. Its comparison-region rise from 39.1% to 46.5% contributed another 7.5 points to the relative divergence. For the army, by contrast, trust fell in both groups, by 29.3 and 7.4 points. Ruling-party trust fell by 24.9 points in the conflict regions against a 2.0-point decline in the comparison regions. Thus the negative relative estimates for these three institutions share a substantial local decline, but not the same comparison-group trajectory.

Other institutions make the distinction especially clear. Parliament’s trust share fell by 10.0 points in the conflict regions and 11.2 points in the comparison regions. Its small positive difference does not mean that public confidence remained stable. Opposition-party trust was almost unchanged in the conflict regions but rose by 14.1 points outside them. The president lost trust in both groups, producing a modest relative difference despite an 18.8-point decline within the conflict regions. These patterns are substantive findings, not qualifications that can be left to robustness checks.

5 Empirical strategy and uncertainty

5.1 The regional comparison

I estimate a separate difference-in-differences regression for each of the eleven institutions. The baseline is an unweighted ordinary least squares (OLS) linear probability model:

$$y_{ijrt} = \alpha_j + \gamma_j C_r + \lambda_{jt} + \sum_{s \in S} \beta_{js} (C_r \times \mathbb{1}[t = s]) + \phi_j' X_{it} + \varepsilon_{ijrt} \quad (1)$$

Here y is the binary trust response of respondent i for institution j , interviewed in administrative region r and survey year t . The conflict-group indicator C equals one in the Northwest and Southwest and zero in West and Littoral. The intercept α and group coefficient γ

are institution-specific; λ denotes institution-specific survey-year effects, with 2015 omitted. The set S contains the three later surveys, 2018, 2021 and 2022, and $\mathbb{1}[t = s]$ is an indicator for the corresponding survey year. The vector X_{it} collects individual covariates, age, sex, and urban residence, with harmonised education categories in a further specification, and ϕ_j is the corresponding institution-specific coefficient vector. Each interaction coefficient β therefore measures the change in the conflict–comparison trust gap relative to 2015. The error ε captures remaining respondent-level variation. These are repeated cross-sections, so the model does not include respondent fixed effects.

In the baseline specification the covariate vector X_{it} is omitted, so equation (1) contains only the regional-group indicator, survey-year indicators, and their interactions; Section 7 explains why some candidate covariates, education in particular, may themselves respond to the crisis, which is why the unadjusted contrast is the baseline. Standard errors are clustered by the four administrative regions; the limitations of this inference and the supplementary bootstrap calculations are discussed below. Table 2 reports the estimated interaction coefficients and their standard errors, multiplied by 100 to express them in percentage points. Covariate-adjusted models add age, sex, and urban residence, with harmonised education categories in a further specification; weighted models use the Afrobarometer survey weights. These alternatives are reported after the main estimates and in Appendix A.

With the covariates omitted, the baseline model is saturated in the group-by-survey means. For each institution and post-2015 survey, its estimated interaction coefficient equals the change in conflict-region trust minus the change in comparison-region trust:

$$\hat{\beta}_{jt} = (\bar{y}_{j,C,t} - \bar{y}_{j,C,2015}) - (\bar{y}_{j,N,t} - \bar{y}_{j,N,2015}) \quad (2)$$

In equation (2), the barred outcomes are sample means for the conflict group C and comparison group N, using substantive responses for institution j in each survey. The replication code verifies that these arithmetic differences equal the regression estimates. For the police in 2022, the calculation is a 21.1-percentage-point decline in the conflict regions minus a

7.5-point increase in the comparison regions, giving -28.6 points. It describes how the two groups diverged relative to their initial gap.

A causal interpretation would require the groups' trust trajectories to have evolved in parallel in the absence of the crisis, alongside assumptions about spillovers, survey coverage, and population composition. Geographic location is not randomly assigned, and the analysis does not measure individual exposure to particular violent events. Stable historical differences can be removed by differencing, but time-varying regional differences cannot. Moreover, if the conflict affects opinions in the comparison regions, the contrast incorporates those responses rather than identifying the total effect on the conflict regions alone.

The estimand therefore needs care. The directly observed quantity is a difference in changes among the respondents reached in successive regional surveys. It is not an average individual change, an effect on people who remained in their original homes, or an estimate for displaced people missed by the sampling frame. Interpreting it as a population or causal effect requires assumptions beyond the repeated observations themselves. I use the estimates to assess differentiated regional trajectories and make causal claims conditional on those assumptions.

5.2 Few regions and multiple institutions

The main design has two conflict regions and two comparison regions. A large number of interviews does not compensate for this small number of geographic units. I report conventional standard errors clustered by region, using a t reference distribution with three degrees of freedom, alongside null-imposed wild-cluster bootstrap calculations that enumerate all 1,296 combinations of six-point Webb weights. These are alternative assessments of uncertainty, not guarantees of reliable size with four regions. The problems created by few clusters and few treated clusters are well established (Cameron and Miller 2015; MacKinnon, Nielsen and Webb 2023).

I also assess how unusual the final-year coefficients are relative to alternative regional

pairings. West and Littoral remain fixed as comparisons; any two of the other eight regions can form a placebo conflict group, giving 28 assignments including the observed pair. A second reference set excludes the Far North and contains 21 assignments. For each pairing, the same estimation procedure is applied to all eleven institutions. I report both institution-specific exceedance shares and shares based on the largest absolute statistic across the eleven outcomes. The latter address the selection involved in highlighting the most extreme institution.

The reference statistic matters. A maximum absolute coefficient preserves the common percentage-point scale. A maximum absolute t statistic additionally scales each coefficient by an estimated standard error. I show both regional-cluster and independent-region-wave versions of that scaling in the appendix. The region-wave calculation assumes independence across the sixteen region-by-round cells and does not resolve serial correlation simply by collapsing the data. It is a sensitivity analysis, not a more conservative default.

These regional assignments are descriptive placebo calibrations. They are not generated by a known random assignment of conflict, and the regions need not be exchangeable. Consequently, their exceedance shares should not be interpreted as exact randomisation p-values or guaranteed family-wise error control. They cover the eleven outcomes at the 2022 end-point, not every outcome, period, and specification investigated in the paper. I report the full pattern and avoid declaring differences in coefficient magnitude established by a single threshold.

6 Comparative results

6.1 Relative changes over time

Table 2 reports the three post-2015 interaction coefficients from equation (1) for every institution. Negative entries mean that trust changed less favourably in the conflict regions than in West and Littoral. They do not by themselves establish an absolute decline or a causal ef-

fect of counterinsurgency. Institutions are presented in a consistent order to aid comparison; position in the table is not a claim that adjacent estimates are statistically distinguishable.

Police trust shows negative relative changes at every post-onset observation: -24.5 points in 2018, -15.2 in 2021 and -28.6 in 2022. This is a persistent relative deficit, but not a monotonic deterioration in the DiD coefficient. Ruling-party trust also has a negative estimate throughout, moving from -29.2 to -26.7 and -22.8 points. The army's estimates are -21.0 , -11.4 and -21.9 points. By the final survey, these are the three largest negative point estimates, although the differences between their magnitudes are not independently established.

The courts and electoral commission also end with negative estimates, at -17.5 and -14.0 points. Their underlying conflict-region trust shares declined, while comparison-region changes were smaller. This is compatible with dissatisfaction extending beyond security forces to institutions involved in governing and administering the political order. It does not identify judicial conduct or electoral performance as the cause. The survey battery does not distinguish evaluations of ordinary service delivery from evaluations specifically related to the conflict.

The presidency and parliament illustrate why relative resilience should not be equated with political insulation. Presidential trust fell appreciably in both groups, leaving a 2022 DiD of -4.4 points. Parliament's estimate is $+1.2$ points despite declining trust in each group. A theory that treats these coefficients as evidence that citizens exempted the president or parliament from responsibility would disregard the absolute changes. Local councils and religious leaders have positive final-year differences of 12.1 and 12.6 points, respectively. These combine small conflict-region increases with larger declines in the comparison regions; they are not evidence of equally large gains in local trust.

6.2 Traditional leaders and the intensity of trust

Traditional leaders display a different temporal pattern. In the conflict regions, the share trusting them somewhat or a lot fell from 51.5% in 2015 to 36.0% in 2018 and 26.0% in 2021, then rose to 44.2% in 2022. Comparison-region shares were much steadier. The corresponding relative estimates are -15.0 , -22.5 and -8.2 points. The final estimate is imprecise and remains below the pre-crisis benchmark; it should not be described as proof of full recovery.

The response distribution qualifies the rebound further. The conflict-region share expressing a lot of trust in traditional leaders declined from 34.5% in 2015 to 8.5% in 2022. When this highest category alone defines the outcome, the final-year relative change is -33.3 points; on the original 0–3 scale it is -0.39 scale points. Recovery at the somewhat-or-a-lot threshold therefore coexists with a lasting loss of strong confidence. The appendix presents equivalent threshold checks for all institutions rather than selecting only the result most favourable to the argument.

Behaviour tracks the collapse more closely than the recovery. Estimated with equation (1), reported contact with a traditional leader during the previous year falls by 17.5 points in 2021, alongside the trough in stated trust, and remains 12.1 points down in 2022 when the binary trust indicator has largely recovered. The share perceiving most or all traditional leaders as corrupt rises in point estimate across the rounds but is never precisely estimated, and I place no weight on it (supplementary Table A20).

This case contributes to the institutional comparison without becoming its organising endpoint. It suggests that a local intermediary can retain or regain moderate acceptance while losing stronger allegiance. The analysis cannot determine whether changing perceptions of protection, collaboration, displacement, or leadership turnover account for that distribution. Nor does it establish that customary authority as a category is more resilient than state authority across contexts.

6.3 What the uncertainty permits

Conventional regional-cluster tests give relatively small p-values for some final-year estimates, including the police and courts, but the wild-bootstrap results are less decisive. For the police, the cluster reference p-value is 0.006 and the enumerated wild-bootstrap value is 0.060. For the ruling party, the corresponding values are 0.031 and 0.062. These calculations reinforce the importance of reporting magnitudes and trajectories without treating a four-region design as a precise experiment.

The 28-assignment placebo comparison likewise depends on the statistic. Using the maximum absolute coefficient across all eleven institutions gives exceedance shares of 0.071 for the police and 0.107 for the ruling party. Using the maximum regional-cluster t statistic gives 0.143 and 0.500. Using t statistics from the independent-region-wave calculation gives 0.036 for both. The divergence is material: it precludes a claim that both results survive all corrections. Excluding the Far North changes the reference set and some of these values again (Appendix A).

Finally, a test of one institution's coefficient against zero is not a test that it differs from another institution's coefficient. The appendix compares institution pairs using within-respondent differences, which retain the covariance between trust responses. Those contrasts also inherit the four-region limitation and can be highly sensitive to variance estimation. I therefore use the comparative pattern to evaluate substantive explanations, while withholding claims that the data identify the differences in magnitude among all eleven coefficients.

7 Robustness and limitations

7.1 Comparison regions and specification

The police's final-year relative decline persists across the reported comparison choices. It is -23.8 points with West alone, -24.2 points using the seven other regions excluding the Far North, and -19.5 points when all eight other regions are included. Excluding Douala

from the adjacent-region sample reduces the magnitude to -22.1 points. Separate Northwest and Southwest comparisons yield negative estimates in each. These exercises show that the baseline pattern is not restricted to a single comparator, but the alternatives change the population being compared and retain possible spillovers and confounding.

Two further cuts are informative. Estimated with a single treated region against the same comparisons (supplementary Table A9), the police deficit is -33.0 points with the Northwest alone and -23.2 with the Southwest alone, so the headline result is not an artefact of either region. The traditional-leaders estimate, by contrast, splits sharply: -18.3 points with the Northwest alone against $+3.7$ with the Southwest alone, so the chieftaincy result is concentrated in the Northwest, the Grassfields heartland where chiefly institutions are strongest and the fighting was most intense. Within the pooled sample, the traditional-leaders effect is roughly twice as large among rural respondents (-21.4 points) as urban ones (-10.5), consistent with the rural concentration of the fighting, while differences by age and education are small (supplementary Table A21).

Using Afrobarometer survey weights gives a police estimate of -30.5 points. Adjustment for age, sex, and urban residence yields -28.0 points; adding the harmonised education categories gives a similar value. These controls describe sensitivity to measured composition. Some characteristics may themselves change through displacement and selective access, so adjustment is not automatically a preferable causal specification. The education measure has four substantive categories, with non-substantive codes excluded; it is not a nine-point attainment scale.

Item non-response can also change the observed composition of substantive answers. Appendix A reports missing-response shares by institution, group and round. Coding all non-substantive responses as zero is a deliberately different definition, not a correction for missing data. Under that definition the police estimate is -30.4 points. The threshold and ordinal results show whether conclusions depend on combining adjacent response categories. For traditional leaders, as noted above, this dependence changes the interpretation of recov-

ery substantially.

Cameroon's other insurgency offers a within-country point of reference, though not a second experiment. The Far North has faced Boko Haram violence since 2014, before the first survey used here, so no pre-crisis baseline exists and the exercise is descriptive. Supplementary Table A19 reports the Far North's gap in trust relative to the seven non-conflict regions in each round, together with the change in that gap relative to 2015. Trust in traditional leaders in the Far North stands 17 to 25 points above the non-conflict regions in every round, at levels between 69% and 86%, and that advantage is essentially unchanged relative to 2015 (-1.6 points by 2022). The police and the courts move very differently: the Far North's police gap of $+28.7$ points in 2015 erodes by 19 to 23 points relative to 2015 across the later rounds, and its courts gap of $+26.6$ points erodes by 24.7 points by 2022. Boko Haram is an external insurgency that does not cast chiefs as agents of a contested state, so the contrast sits comfortably with a role-based reading, but it carries no causal weight and the Far North is excluded from the broader comparison group throughout.

7.2 Pre-crisis trajectories

The 2013 survey makes one earlier change observable for nine institutions. Between 2013 and 2015, the police regional difference-in-changes is approximately -0.6 points. Its small estimate is reassuring about that particular interval but provides only a weak check on the unobserved post-2015 counterfactual. Other institutions show larger pre-crisis differences, including $+10.4$ points for the ruling party and $+8.8$ for the electoral commission. Their assessments also differ across conventional clustered and placebo reference calculations.

A single earlier interval cannot establish parallel trends, especially with four regions. Failure to reject a pre-trend may reflect low power, while conditioning conclusions on a favourable pretest can distort inference (Roth 2022). Traditional and religious leaders have no second pre-crisis observation in these data. I therefore do not treat the pre-crisis exercise as validation of the identifying assumption or use the ratio of a post-crisis coefficient to an

imprecisely estimated pre-trend as a formal robustness bound.

7.3 Survey access and changing populations

The largest design concern may be who could be interviewed as the crisis progressed. Survey observations remain in both core conflict regions, but stable regional counts do not imply stable coverage of locations or people. The available data show marked changes in the interview environment. In the conflict-region sample, the proportion interviewed in areas reporting a police station in the enumeration area or within easy walking distance rises from 12% in 2015 to 100% in 2021 and 88% in 2022. The share of interviews conducted in Pidgin falls from 35% in 2015 to less than 1% in 2022. Other demographic and interviewer-assessed characteristics also change.

These indicators warrant concern without uniquely diagnosing its source. They could reflect changes in security infrastructure, access, sampled locations, respondents, or recording practices. The 2015 conflict-region sample does contain respondents in areas with a police station: there are 24 valid police-trust responses in that category. Thus an assertion that pre- and post-crisis samples have no overlap on this observed characteristic would be incorrect. At the same time, overlap on one indicator cannot establish comparable coverage, and a large trust decline does not rule out selection bias.

The data used here do not link respondents or reliably establish continuous residence in the same communities across rounds. The analysis cannot recover attitudes among inaccessible households, people who fled abroad or displaced people absent from the relevant sampling frame. Nor can it isolate truthful expression from changes in willingness to criticise institutions during face-to-face interviews. Interviewer assessments of respondent ease are descriptive evidence about context, not a validated correction for fear or social desirability. Appendix A makes these observed changes visible rather than interpreting them as proof that selection is harmless.

8 Interpretation and conclusion

The central question concerns institutional differentiation during counterinsurgency. The most prominent final-year regional divergence is in police trust, followed in point-estimate magnitude by the ruling party and army. These institutions combine coercive or political responsibility with substantial absolute declines in the conflict-region sample. The pattern makes an account centred on institutional roles plausible. It does not establish that respondents blamed a particular actor for a particular act, or that proximity and formal status played no part. Nor is the pattern an artefact of mean reversion: across the eleven institutions the 2022 estimate is positively correlated with the 2015 conflict-region level (+0.40), the opposite of what regression to the mean would produce (supplementary Table A22).

The evidence also challenges overly simple versions of that account. The president lost trust in both regional groups, so the modest presidential DiD cannot be used to exempt national leadership from perceived responsibility. Parliament likewise experienced declining trust despite its near-zero relative estimate. Opposition-party trust provides an especially clear case in which change outside the conflict's core drives much of the regional divergence. Traditional leaders' partial binary recovery coexists with diminished strong trust. These cases show why neither a single index of institutions nor the relative size of coefficients alone adequately describes the public response.

The comparison regions belong in the explanation. Police trust moved in opposite directions across groups, a descriptive pattern consistent with geographically differentiated evaluations of security. Yet comparison-region trust in the president, ruling party, and army all declined. The data therefore do not show a uniform rally around the government outside the conflict zone. Selective approval of policing, national political dissatisfaction, shifting information, and changes in who was surveyed remain possible explanations. Establishing a conflict-induced rally or polarisation mechanism would require evidence beyond these regional means.

The findings have a bounded practical implication. Confidence in community author-

ities cannot be assumed to imply confidence in security institutions, and a small relative coefficient cannot be taken as evidence that an institution needs no repair. Monitoring legitimacy during conflict should distinguish institutions, degrees of trust, and the publics whose opinions are changing. Assessments of recovery should inspect strong as well as moderate confidence.

Further research could strengthen identification through more pre-crisis observations, better documentation of survey substitutions and inaccessible areas, and measures linking institutional evaluations to specific encounters and attributions of responsibility. The present data cannot eliminate those limitations. They nevertheless establish a robust central finding: the counterinsurgency coincided with a collapse of trust in the police in the regions where it was fought, the largest and most specification-stable deficit among the eleven institutions, set within sharply uneven trajectories across the rest of the battery and across regional publics. Explaining that unevenness requires observing both sides of the regional comparison and distinguishing the loss of trust from the loss of trust relative to somewhere else.

Competing interests

The author declares none.

Data availability

All data are from the publicly available Afrobarometer merged files for Rounds 5 to 9 (afrobarometer.org/data). Code and constructed datasets reproducing every table and figure, including the harmonisation of question numbers across rounds documented in supplementary Table A18, are available from the author and will be deposited in a public repository on acceptance.

Use of artificial intelligence

During the preparation of this work, the author used Claude (Anthropic), accessed through the Claude application during 2026, to assist with code development, construction of the harmonised datasets, and editing of the text. The author reviewed and edited all content and takes full responsibility for the content of the article.

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Table 1: Trust levels and changes from 2015 to 2022

Institution	C levels 2015 → 2022	N levels 2015 → 2022	ΔC	ΔN	DiD
Police	30.7 → 9.5	39.1 → 46.5	-21.1	+7.5	-28.6
Ruling party	37.7 → 12.8	29.7 → 27.6	-24.9	-2.0	-22.8
Army	44.4 → 15.2	75.4 → 67.9	-29.3	-7.4	-21.9
Courts	39.3 → 22.6	35.6 → 36.4	-16.7	+0.8	-17.5
Opposition parties	25.0 → 23.8	17.7 → 31.8	-1.2	+14.1	-15.2
Electoral commission	34.8 → 15.7	33.1 → 28.0	-19.1	-5.1	-14.0
Traditional leaders	51.5 → 44.2	49.1 → 50.0	-7.3	+0.9	-8.2
President	45.5 → 26.7	68.8 → 54.4	-18.8	-14.4	-4.4
Parliament	33.5 → 23.5	41.0 → 29.8	-10.0	-11.2	+1.2
Local council	32.2 → 33.0	36.6 → 25.4	+0.8	-11.2	+12.1
Religious leaders	64.0 → 66.7	67.0 → 57.1	+2.7	-9.9	+12.6

Notes: C: Northwest and Southwest. N: West and Littoral. Levels are percentages trusting *somewhat* or *a lot*; changes and DiD are percentage points. Δ denotes 2022 minus 2015. $DiD = \Delta C - \Delta N$. Rounding may cause displayed differences to differ by 0.1 point. All entries are unweighted; item-specific denominators appear in supplementary Appendix A.

Table 2: Regression estimates of changes in institutional trust

Institution	2018	2021	2022	Wild p , 2022	N
Police	−24.5 (4.9)	−15.2 (1.3)	−28.6 (4.2)	0.060	1,880
Ruling party	−29.2 (6.2)	−26.7 (5.4)	−22.8 (6.0)	0.062	1,820
Army	−21.0 (2.1)	−11.4 (4.8)	−21.9 (8.0)	0.182	1,868
Courts	−23.7 (7.6)	−12.8 (3.5)	−17.5 (2.7)	0.051	1,850
Opposition parties	−7.7 (5.4)	−21.0 (9.2)	−15.2 (8.8)	0.187	1,806
Electoral commission	−23.8 (7.5)	−19.7 (4.9)	−14.0 (4.9)	0.054	1,828
Traditional leaders	−15.0 (3.7)	−22.5 (9.2)	−8.2 (9.0)	0.563	1,857
President	−25.1 (5.1)	−11.8 (10.3)	−4.4 (14.0)	0.796	1,818
Parliament	−19.6 (11.6)	−6.8 (9.2)	+1.2 (9.2)	0.892	1,805
Local council	−10.6 (5.5)	−8.5 (1.3)	+12.1 (7.2)	0.373	1,799
Religious leaders	+12.3 (3.5)	+1.8 (12.8)	+12.6 (4.3)	0.057	1,866

Notes: Separate unweighted OLS linear probability models by institution, as in equation (1). Entries are conflict-group $\times$ survey-year coefficients and parenthesised regional-cluster standard errors, both multiplied by 100. Every model includes the group indicator and survey-year effects, uses 2015 as the reference, and excludes individual covariates. N is the number of substantive responses across 2015–2022; there are four regions. Wild p enumerates 1,296 null-imposed Webb-weight draws for the 2022 coefficient. Small-cluster inference remains approximate. Full reference calculations appear in supplementary Appendix A.

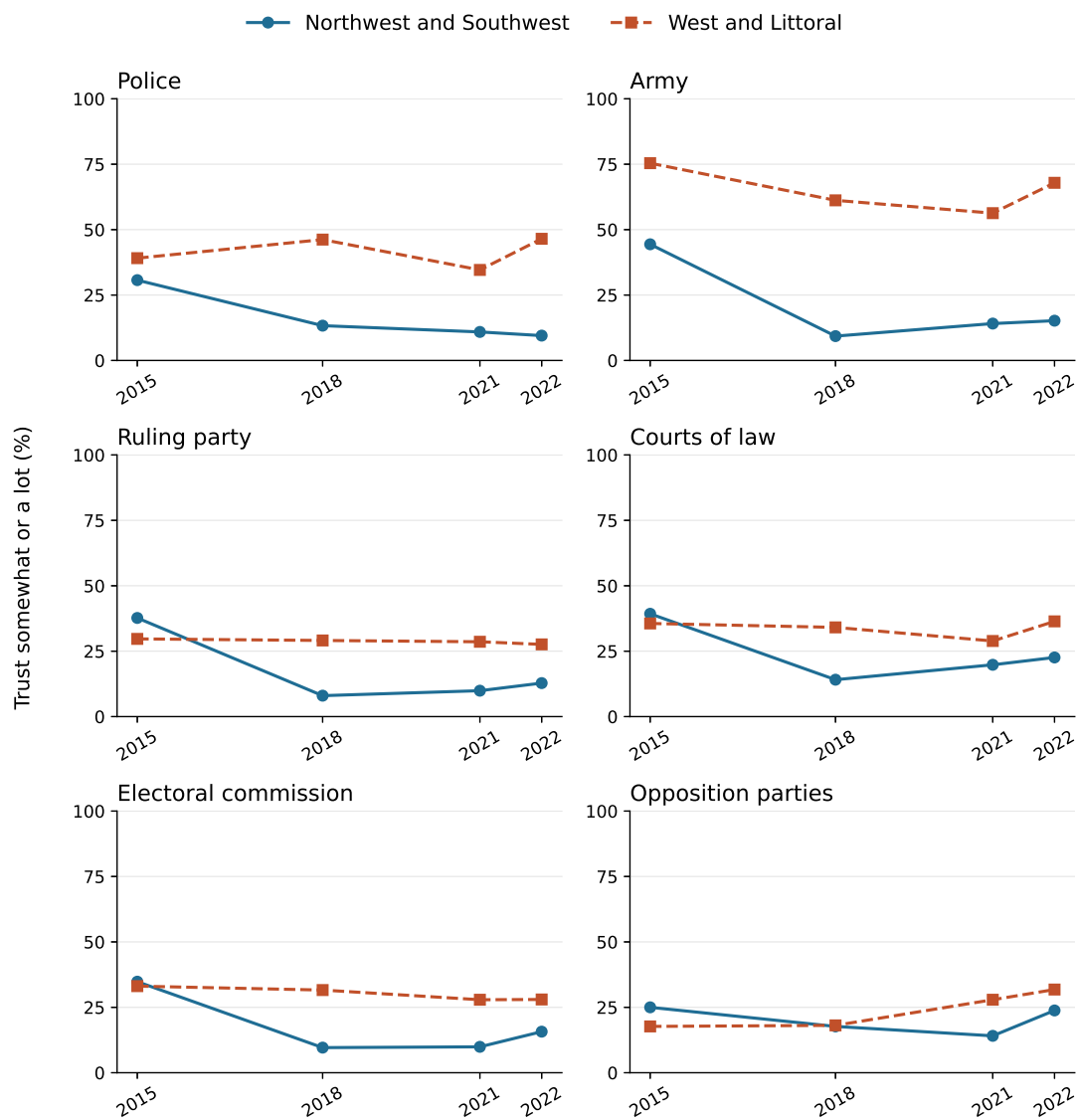


Figure 1: Trust in political and security institutions by regional group. *Source:* Afrobarometer, Cameroon Rounds 6–9. Unweighted substantive-response means; trust equals *somewhat* or *a lot*. Points are survey observations; connecting lines do not represent annual measurements. Exact values and denominators appear in supplementary Appendix A.

Alt text: Six line charts (police, army, ruling party, courts of law, electoral commission, opposition parties) showing the percentage trusting each institution in 2015, 2018, 2021, and 2022; solid circles are the Northwest and Southwest, dashed squares West and Littoral. Police trust falls from 31 to 10 per cent in the conflict regions while rising outside them; the other institutions fall steeply in the conflict regions against flatter comparison series, except opposition parties, whose trust rises in the comparison regions.

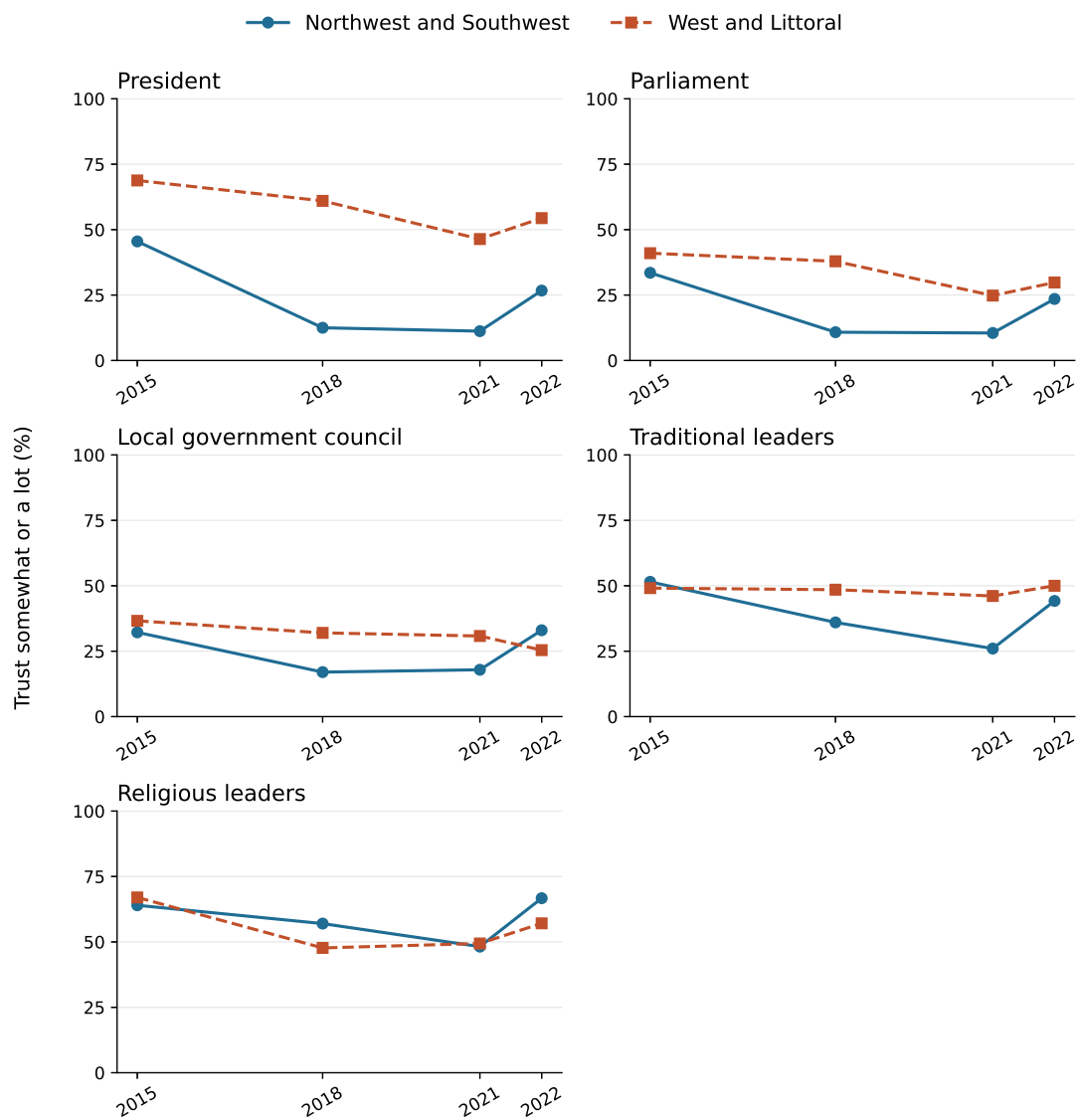


Figure 2: Trust in representative and community institutions by regional group. *Source:* Afrobarometer, Cameroon Rounds 6–9. Unweighted substantive-response means; trust equals *somewhat* or *a lot*. Points are survey observations; connecting lines do not represent annual measurements. Exact values and denominators appear in supplementary Appendix A.

Alt text: Five line charts (president, parliament, local government council, traditional leaders, religious leaders) in the same format as Figure 1. Presidential and parliamentary trust decline in both regional groups; traditional-leaders trust falls to 26 per cent in the conflict regions by 2021 and recovers to 44 per cent in 2022 against a flat comparison series; religious leaders dip and recover.